

Chicago Tribune



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FRIDAY, JUNE 19, 2026

CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

OBAMA PRESIDENTIAL CENTER



A ‘beacon of hope’

Thousands pack Midway Plaisance Park to watch livestream of ceremony

By Rebecca Johnson
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

While Jackie Mills waited for the dedication ceremony for the Obama Presidential Center to start, she found herself reminiscing on former President Barack Obama’s first inauguration.

Her entire family gathered in her mother’s home, huddled around the television, the 72-year-old Bronzeville resident said. Her mom had insisted all of Mills’ brothers and sisters take off work to be a part of the “massive holiday.”

Her mom was incredibly proud — and a bit shocked — that a Black man had been elected president. For Mills it was impossible not to cry. On Thursday, she felt similar emotions.

“This is a historic event. A once in a lifetime thing,” she said. “We will never see this again ... They’re going to save this neighborhood.”

Mills was one of thousands who packed Midway Plaisance Park to watch a livestream of the star-studded ceremony on a large screen, sitting on lawn chairs and blankets. Many were ecstatic about the newest 19-acre addition to Jackson Park, just steps away from

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Above: Letitia Dennis, of Park Manor, tears up as she stands with her granddaughter Tatum Horton-Tucker, 4, as they listen to Jennifer Hudson sing the national anthem during the watch party for the opening ceremony of the Obama Presidential Center at Midway Plaisance Park in Hyde Park on Thursday. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

At top: Daughters Sasha and Malia, from left, former first lady Michelle Obama and former President Barack Obama laugh during the Obama Presidential Center dedication ceremony on Thursday. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

INSIDE: The Obama Center’s A-list opening, or: The art of having famous friends. **Page A4**
■ MS NOW goes all in on the opening, as national media flock to the South Side. **Business**

Obama urges Americans to look past political turbulence at dedication

By A.D. Quig and Rick Pearson
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The Obama Presidential Center was dedicated Thursday in Jackson Park to the sounds of celebration and aspiration, music and motivation to amplify Barack and Michelle Obama’s message that it serve as a “beacon of hope” for democracy and help pave the way for a new generation of political leadership.

Surrounded by former Democratic Presidents Joe Biden and Bill Clinton and Republican ex-President George W. Bush, their spouses, former foreign leaders, federal, state and local politicians and a bevy of celebrities, former President Barack Obama urged Americans to look past the political turbulence and controversies of the Trump era that have fostered cynicism and to recapture the message of hope and change that catapulted him to the White House in 2008.

President Donald Trump was pointedly not invited to the dedication. His name went unspoken by Barack and Michelle Obama, or any other speaker during the three-hour ceremony — a notable silence given that the current president has long mocked the

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Illinois tornado tally closes in on record of 142

Only halfway through year, experts say pace not normal

By Adriana Pérez, Allison Kiehl and Jack O’Connor
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A barrage of tornadoes has hit Illinois communities this year, bringing the tally to just under 140. Some have amounted to nothing more than a swirl of high winds and no reported damage. Many have collapsed homes, injured people and devastated crops in their wake.

Experts say this pace is not normal: Illinois experienced an average of 54 tornadoes annually between 1990 and 2020. The most it has ever recorded in a year was 142 in 2024 — a record that, only halfway through 2026, the state is close to shattering as field



Debris lies on the ground on March 11 after a tornado struck the evening before along South Sandbar Road in Aroma Park. The homes border the Kankakee River. **STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

surveys wrap up and reports are confirmed from Wednesday’s storms. Even in a busy 2024, only 87 tornadoes had hit the state as of June 18, according to NOAA data.

“The update for Illinois is, we just keep getting nailed by tornadoes,” Trent Ford,

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US lifts its blockade of Iran, and ayatollah endorses negotiations

But Vance announces ceremonial signing trip could be delayed

By Will Weissert and Seung Min Kim
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — The U.S. on Thursday lifted its blockade of Iran, and oil tankers began freely moving through the Strait of Hormuz after months of being unable to use the critical channel, as the tentative agreement to end the war took effect.

Meanwhile, Vice President JD Vance announced that he may postpone a trip to Switzerland that had been planned for Friday and was to include a ceremonial signing of the deal. The visit might have helped start talks on the next, potentially even more critical, round of negotiations between the two sides.

Hours later, Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei endorsed direct negotiations with the U.S. in a state-

ment read by state media.

“It is obvious that the face-to-face negotiations that will be held in the future will not mean accepting the enemy’s opinion,” he said.

It was Khamenei’s first reaction to the agreement, and it indicated a shift in Iran’s approach. Hard-liners, especially Khamenei’s father, the previous supreme leader, have long opposed direct talks, especially after the U.S. pulled out of the 2015 nuclear deal between Iran and world powers.

The supreme leader has not been seen in public since he was wounded in a strike at the start of the war.

Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif also postponed a planned visit to Switzerland, where Islamabad officials were to

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